

Hackles Teacher Academy: Plain-Language Glossary

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

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FIELD COPY

1



Lock It

PASSWORDS AND ACCOUNTS

2



Spot It

SCAMS AND FAKES

3



Share Smart

PRIVACY

4



Safe People

WHO TO TRUST

5



Kind and Well

KINDNESS AND BALANCE

6



Fix It

TELL, REPAIR, RECOVER

PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

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Words you will meet in the Academy and in your students' world, explained without jargon. If a definition ever sounds like a manual, we have failed: tell us.

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Slang and platform terms change quickly. Entries marked [VERIFY] should be checked against current sources before you rely on them.

A

Account takeover. When someone other than you gets into your account (a game, email or social app) and uses it. Often starts with a fake login page, a leaked and reused password, or a code someone was tricked into giving away. *Kid version:* "Someone else is using my account."

AI (artificial intelligence). Computer programs that do tasks that seem "smart," like writing text, making pictures or answering questions. They learn patterns from large amounts of data. They can be helpful and they can be wrong.

AI companion. A chatbot built to act like a friend, character or confidant, and often to remember past chats. It can feel caring, but it is not a person. *Teaching point:* fine for fun; not a substitute for a trusted adult.

App permissions. The "may I use your camera, microphone, location or contacts?" questions an app asks. *Check:* does it actually need that to work?

B

Backup. A second copy of important files stored somewhere else, so a lost or broken device does not mean lost files.

Block. A setting that stops someone from contacting you on an app. *Compare:* **report**.

Bot. A program that acts automatically. Some bots are helpful; some are used to send spam or scams.

C

Chatbot. A program that writes replies like a person in a chat. See **AI companion**.

Check (Hackles step). The third part of the routine: *Is it real? Who is it from? What do they want?* Includes checking another way (calling a known number, asking a trusted adult).

CIPA (Children's Internet Protection Act). A US law linked to school and library internet funding that requires an internet safety policy including education on appropriate online behavior. [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: usac.org/e-rate/applicant-process/starting-services/cipa]

COPPA (Children's Online Privacy Protection Act). A US law about how online services collect personal information from children under 13. [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: [ftc.gov COPPA rule page](https://ftc.gov/COPPA). The amended rule was published April 22, 2025, took effect June 23, 2025, and has a compliance deadline of April 22, 2026.]

Cybersecurity. Protecting devices, accounts and information from being stolen, damaged or misused. In the Academy: passwords, phishing, privacy, updates and backups.

Cyberbullying. Unkind or harmful behavior online, repeated or public, such as mean group chats, spreading screenshots or embarrassing posts.

D

Deepfake. A fake picture, video or voice made with AI to look or sound real. Some are used to embarrass, scam or threaten people. Making or sharing a deepfake of a classmate is abuse and may be a crime. [Confirm your state law with district counsel]

DM (direct message). A private message between one person and another (or a few people).

Disclosure. When a child tells an adult something about harm, fear or danger. A disclosure is the curriculum working, not failing.

Doxxing (doxing). Revealing someone's private information (such as a home address or school) online without permission.

E

Encryption. Scrambling information so that only the intended person can read it. Many messaging apps use it. It protects content from outsiders; it does not make a person safe from someone they are chatting with.

EAP (Employee Assistance Program). A confidential support service many employers offer for personal and work stress. [VERIFY your district's EAP]

F

False alarm. When a child's hackles go up over something that turns out to be harmless. In Hackles, false alarms are **fine and welcome**.

FERPA (Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act). A US law protecting the privacy of student education records at schools that receive US Department of Education funds. Parents have rights to inspect and seek to amend records and to some control over disclosure, and those rights pass to the student at 18 or on enrolling in a postsecondary institution. [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: studentprivacy.ed.gov]

Filter. Software that blocks some websites or content. Helpful, never enough on its own.

G

Gift-card scam. A trick that asks for payment in gift cards (because they are hard to trace). Real organizations do not demand gift cards.

Grooming. A process in which someone builds trust with a child, often with flattery, gifts, special attention and secrecy, in order to exploit them. Teach the **pattern** (pressure, secrecy, the ask, the move), not a scary label.

Group chat. A shared conversation among several people.

H

Hackles. What rises on the back of your neck when something feels off. In the program: the feeling of "uh-oh" that a child learns to notice and act on.

Hackles up? The first step of the routine: *notice* that something feels odd, too good, pushy, secret or scary.

Hackle. The friendly baby-hedgehog mascot whose pale-yellow, tangerine-tipped quills stand up when something is off. Appears in K-5 materials; a small corner icon in grades 6-12.

Hook. The first two minutes of a Hackles lesson: a story, riddle or question that sets a calm tone and names the skill.

I

IEP / 504 plan. Documents describing the supports and accommodations a student with a disability receives at school. [VERIFY your school's procedures]

Identity theft. Using someone's personal information to pretend to be them or to get money or credit.

L

L.E.A.R.N. A five-step way to answer a worried parent: Listen, Empathize, Agree where you can, Respond with facts and options, Next step.

Left on read. Message was seen but not answered. A common source of social pressure in chats.

M

Malware. Harmful software, such as viruses or ransomware, designed to damage or steal.

Mandated reporter. A person the law requires to report suspected child abuse or neglect. Most school staff are. *Rules vary by state.* [Confirm your state at childwelfare.gov and with district counsel]

Micro-teach. A short practice lesson delivered to colleagues, with feedback from a rubric.

N

NCMEC. The National Center for Missing and Exploited Children. Runs the **CyberTipline** for reporting online exploitation (report.cybertip.org, 1-800-843-5678) and **Take It Down** (takeitdown.ncmec.org). [VERIFY contact details]

Nudify app. An app that uses AI to create a fake nude image from a normal photo. Creating or sharing such images of a minor is abuse and may be a crime. [Federal law verified 2026-10-05 (18 U.S.C. 2252A, 2256); confirm state law with district counsel]

O

Open door. The closing line of a Hackles lesson: "If anything today made you think of something, tell me, the counselor or write a note. You will never be in trouble for telling."

Opt-out. A family's right (where your district offers it) to have a child skip specific lessons. See the Counselor Heads-Up and Opt-Out Toolkit.

P

Passkey. A way to log in without typing a password: a cryptographic key stored on your device, unlocked by fingerprint, face or screen lock. Very hard to steal in a phishing message. Many sync across your devices through your phone or browser account, so plan for recovery. *Kid version:* "a magic key that only works on my device, when I say 'it's me.'"

Passphrase. A password made of several unrelated words (for example, four or five). Long, silly and memorable.

Password manager. An app or browser feature that creates and stores strong passwords so you only remember one master passphrase. *Kid version:* "a locked notebook that remembers all my keys."

Pause (Hackles step). The second step: stop, breathe, do nothing yet. Not clicking, not replying, not paying, not sending.

Pause Palm. The hand signal for Pause: palm out like "stop."

Phishing. A message designed to trick you into clicking, logging in, paying or giving away information. It can arrive by email, text, chat, a call or a pop-up.

Privacy. Deciding who gets to know what about you. Not hiding; choosing.

Q

QR code scam ("quishing"). A trick using a QR code that leads to a fake website or a malicious download. Treat QR codes like links. [VERIFY]

R

Ransomware. Malware that locks your files and demands payment to unlock them. Backups defeat it.

Recovery map. A plan for getting back into an account if a device is lost: the second lock, a recovery email, a trusted person and saved recovery codes.

Reasonable suspicion. The usual legal standard for a mandated report: a belief, based on what you have seen or heard, that harm may have occurred. It is **not** proof. [VERIFY your state]

Rehearsal. Practice of a skill out loud or with the body (role-play, scripts, hand signals). The central teaching method in Hackles.

Report. In apps: tell the platform to review a person or content. In the law: tell child protective services or law enforcement as required. In Hackles: the last step of STOP, SAVE, TELL, REPORT.

Role-play. Acting out a situation to practice. In Hackles: short, scripted, with puppets or cards for younger children, and never with real personal details.

S

Screenshot. A picture of what is on a screen. It can save proof and it can spread something.

Scam. A trick to get money, information or access, often using urgency, secrecy or "too good to be true."

Secondary traumatic stress. Emotional strain from hearing about another person's trauma. Common among teachers, counselors and others who receive disclosures. See Module 6. [VERIFY with a mental health source if you cite it]

Sextortion. Threatening to share a private picture (real or fake) unless the target pays or sends more. Most commonly financially motivated and targets teens, especially boys 14 to 17, but any child can be targeted. [NCMEC (2025) reports more than 50,000 financially motivated sextortion reports; the "boys 14 to 17" detail was not found on the NCMEC or Thorn pages read on 2026-10-05, so treat it as a common pattern, not a statistic.] It is never the child's fault.

Shame-free language. Words that thank, reassure and normalize rather than blame: "I'm glad you told me. These tricks fool a lot of people."

Skill. Something a child can *do*, as opposed to something they only *know*.

Social engineering. Tricking people (not computers) into giving access or information, often by pretending to be someone trustworthy.

Spiral curriculum. Revisiting the same skills at greater depth over time, so they stick.

STOP, SAVE, TELL, REPORT. The student plan for pressure or threats: **Stop** responding (do not pay or send more); **Save** text evidence (messages, usernames, dates), do not delete, and never save or share images; **Tell** a trusted adult; **Report** to the platform and to authorities.

Streak. A count of consecutive days of messaging on some apps, which can create social pressure.

T

Take It Down. An NCMEC service that helps remove or stop the spread of intimate images of people under 18 on participating platforms. [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: takeitdown.ncmec.org]

Takeaway. The last two minutes of a Hackles lesson: skill + gesture + the promise.

Teach-back. Explaining what you learned to someone else in your own words, to check and spread understanding.

Tell (Hackles step). The fourth step: tell a trusted adult, every time, with no shame. A hand-on-heart reach-out gesture (Tell Wave).

Tell-Readiness. A simple indicator from the Assessment Pack: the share of students who give the best answers on core "would you tell?" items.

Threat model. Asking: what am I protecting, from whom, and what could go wrong? Taught at 9-12 in "Threat-Model Yourself."

Trusted adult. Someone who listens, helps and keeps a child safe. Can be a family member, teacher, counselor, nurse, coach, faith leader or neighbor.

Two-step verification (2SV, 2FA, MFA). A second proof beyond your password, such as an app code, a prompt or a security key. A "second lock."
Rule: a code is a key; never read it out to someone who asks.

U

Update. A new version of software, often fixing security holes. Turn on automatic updates.

Upstander. Someone who does something helpful when they see unkindness: checks in, says "not cool," saves evidence, tells an adult.

V

Voice cloning. AI that copies someone's voice from a short sample. Used in "family emergency" scam calls. *Defense:* hang up, call back on a known number, use a family code word.

W

Wait time. A silent pause of 3 to 5 seconds after asking a question, to let everyone think.

Z

Zero-background. A teacher with no technical knowledge. Welcome. You are exactly who this course is for.

Quick decoder: words kids use

These change fast. Treat as conversation starters. [VERIFY current usage]

WORD	ROUGH MEANING
GC	Group chat
SS	Screenshot
Sus	Suspicious
Cap / no cap	A lie / not a lie
GG	Good game
Lurk	Read without posting
Doxx	Reveal private information
Handle	A username
Mute	Silence someone's notifications without blocking

This glossary is educational guidance, not legal advice.